

Computational Modeling for Psychology Students

Britt Anderson

Winter 2026

Contents

1	Welcome to Psych 420	1
1.1	Introductions	1
1.2	What is computational cognitive (neuro)science?	2
1.3	Syllabus Review	2
1.3.1	Course number and title	2
1.3.2	Term and year of offering	2
1.3.3	Class days, times, building, and room number	2
1.3.4	Class instructor's name, office, contact information, office hours	2
1.3.5	Teaching assistant's name, office, contact information, office hours (if applicable)	2
1.3.6	Course description	2
1.3.7	Course objectives	3
1.3.8	Required text and/or readings	3
1.3.9	A general overview of the topics to be covered	3
1.3.10	The evaluation structure for the course including course requirements, deadlines, weight of requirements to- ward the final course grade	3
1.3.11	Acceptable rules for group work (See Group Assign- ment Checklist)	4
1.3.12	Indication of how late submission of assignments and missed assignments will be treated	5
1.3.13	Indication of where students are to submit assign- ments and pick up marked assignments	5
1.3.14	Intellectual Property	5
1.3.15	Chosen/Preferred First Name	6
1.3.16	Mental Health Support	6

1.3.17	Territorial Acknowledgement	7
1.3.18	Policy 33, Ethical Behaviour	7
1.4	A look ahead – what we will code	7
1.5	A look ahead – what we talk about	8
1.6	What is Cognition?	8
1.7	Is a mathematical formula a model?	8
1.7.1	Forgetting Curve — Ebbinghaus	8
1.7.2	A Mathematical Function	8
1.7.3	What can we infer	8
1.7.4	Generate your own plot of the exponential function.	8
2	Warming Up: Action Potentials	8
2.1	What is an action potential?	10
2.2	Notation	11
2.3	Differential Equations	11
2.3.1	Using a DE	12
2.3.2	Using DEs to compute a square root	12
2.3.3	Practice Simulating With DEs	13
3	What is computation and what is its role in cognitive science?	15
3.1	What do you think?	15
3.2	What do we need to know?	15
4		16
5	Theory	16
6	Math and Code	17

1 Welcome to Psych 420

1.1 Introductions

1. Who am I?
2. Who are you? Send me an email (britt@uwaterloo.ca) right now (from your uwaterloo address) with
 - (a) Your name (and any pronunciation tips).
 - (b) Area of concentration,

- (c) Year of study,
 - (d) Programming language you are most capable in (and your level of competency),
 - (e) Reason you took this course.
3. What you will need: A functioning computer that you know how to use. What to do now:
- Update your operating system.
 - Verify you know how to find a file on your computer (e.g. do you know the name of your home directory)?
 - Confirm you know how to install software on your computer.
 - You know (or will know by next week) what `git` is and how to use it, and that you will have an IDE installed.

1.2 What is computational cognitive (neuro)science?

1. Form teams of two (or three if odd number).
2. Go to the following web site: 2025 Posters Cognitive Computational Neuroscience meeting.
 - (a) Pick a poster. Note it's label (letter-number; on the left)
 - (b) Be ready with a two sentence summary.
 - (c) Tell us why it is a good example of computational modelling of either mind or brain.
 - (d) Why you chose it.

1.3 Syllabus Review

1.3.1 Course number and title

PSYCH420 Introduction to Computational Neuroscience Methods

1.3.2 Term and year of offering

Winter 2026

1.3.3 Class days, times, building, and room number

Th 11:30 - 14:20 HH 2107

1.3.4 Class instructor's name, office, contact information, office hours

Britt Anderson, PAS 4032, x 43056, Office hours by arrangement

1.3.5 Teaching assistant's name, office, contact information, office hours (if applicable)

1.3.6 Course description

An introduction to the basic elements of computational modeling with an emphasis on psychology students.

1.3.7 Course objectives

1. You will understand the scope of subjects and tools that comprise computational neuroscience and computational cognitive modeling.
2. You will have a better understanding of theory development and how it relates to ideas about computation, programming, mind and brain.
3. You will have a better understanding of how programming language choice influences model and theory development.
4. You will learn some of the fundamental notation and concepts of the mathematical domains that form the basis of much computational modeling in neuroscience and psychology.
5. You will gain experience in the practical aspects of programming simple models by doing.

1.3.8 Required text and/or readings

There is no required text book. Material that might be needed outside what I present in class will be made available on line, predominantly at the course repo on github. Make sure you are tracking the **W2026** branch.

As all University students should have access to a computer, and a computer is required for this course, there is \$0 CAD additional expense.

1.3.9 A general overview of the topics to be covered

See Course objectives.

1.3.10 The evaluation structure for the course including course requirements, deadlines, weight of requirements toward the final course grade

Category	Contribution
Participation	12%.
Final Project	20%.
Homeworks	68%

It is easy to find high quality material to read or watch. What good then is the classroom? The classroom is for doing and clarifying. You have no way of knowing if your understanding developed from online material is complete or accurate unless you match it off against others. Your peers and your instructor. Thus, we shouldn't use class time for presenting material that can be read or watched anywhere anytime, but we should use it for testing whether your knowledge is sound, flexible, and deployable. We will therefore read, discuss, and collaborate.

Learning math and computing, and how to use them, is not something that can be learned through observation. Like playing piano, or improving your golf swing, improvement comes from practice, practice, practice. It is not enough to merely state the principles. You must demonstrate that they have been internalized. We will therefore do small exercises in class. And since one of the best ways to learn is to teach, we will frequently do these exercises in small groups. You might find your peers description of a problematic fact more useful than mine since they are at a more similar learning level. You may find your own understanding grows as you have to reframe my teachings in your own words to help a fellow student grasp a difficult concept.

For these reasons class participation is important. It is where we will test our comprehension of important points, I will learn if a concept is not well appreciated, and you will have the chance to practice the skills you later may wish to use in your own way on your own problems. Each week's attendance is worth 1% of the final grade.

I like to give lots of small homeworks. That takes the pressure of any one assignment, and means you get both frequent feedback on your performance, and you are coerced into not falling behind.

The final project is meant to give you an opportunity to showcase your learning and to use the general and specific skills that you will use in the future, whether in academics or industry, for sharing complex technical material with others.

1.3.11 Acceptable rules for group work (See Group Assignment Checklist)

Group work is the norm in post-graduate life (both academic and professional). Group work will be graded as a group. All group members will get the same grade for their group project. More details on the nature of the group project will be shared during the term.

1.3.12 Indication of how late submission of assignments and missed assignments will be treated

If I know that an assignment will be late in advance, and the reason for the tardiness is beyond your reasonable control, then I probably won't take off any points for late submission. Otherwise, I may reduce the possible maximal score by 10% per week.

1.3.13 Indication of where students are to submit assignments and pick up marked assignments

Assignments will be submitted in dropboxes on Learn. Submissions and Announcements are the main uses we will make of learn. All other material will be shared in class or via the github repository.

1.3.14 Intellectual Property

Intellectual property includes items such as:

- Lecture content, spoken and written (and any audio/video recording thereof);
- Lecture handouts, presentations, and other materials prepared for the course (e.g., PowerPoint slides);
- Questions or solution sets from various types of assessments (e.g., assignments, quizzes, tests, final exams); and
- Work protected by copyright (e.g., any work authored by the instructor or TA or used by the instructor or TA with permission of the copyright owner).

Course materials and the intellectual property contained therein, are used to enhance a student's educational experience. However, sharing this intellectual property without the intellectual property owner's permission is

a violation of intellectual property rights. For this reason, it is necessary to ask the instructor, TA and/or the University of Waterloo for permission before uploading and sharing the intellectual property of others online (e.g., to an online repository).

Permission from an instructor, TA or the University is also necessary before sharing the intellectual property of others from completed courses with students taking the same/similar courses in subsequent terms/years. In many cases, instructors might be happy to allow distribution of certain materials. However, doing so without expressed permission is considered a violation of intellectual property rights.

Please alert the instructor if you become aware of intellectual property belonging to others (past or present) circulating, either through the student body or online. The intellectual property rights owner deserves to know (and may have already given their consent).

1.3.15 Chosen/Preferred First Name

Do you want professors and interviewers to call you by a different first name? Take a minute now to verify or tell us your chosen/preferred first name by logging into WatIAM.

Why? Starting in winter 2020, your chosen/preferred first name listed in WatIAM will be used broadly across campus (e.g., LEARN, Quest, WaterlooWorks, WatCard, etc). Note: Your legal first name will always be used on certain official documents. For more details, visit Updating Personal Information.

Important notes

If you included a preferred name on your OUAC application, it will be used as your chosen/preferred name unless you make a change now. If you don't provide a chosen/preferred name, your legal first name will continue to be used.

1.3.16 Mental Health Support

All of us need a support system. The faculty and staff in Arts encourage students to seek out mental health support if they are needed.

1. On Campus

Counselling Services: counselling.services@uwaterloo.ca / 519-888-4567 ext. 32655 MATES: one-to-one peer support program offered by the Waterloo Undergraduate Student Association (WUSA) and Counselling Services

2. Off campus, 24/7

Good2Talk: Free confidential help line for post-secondary students. Phone: 1-866-925-5454 Grand River Hospital: Emergency care for mental health crisis. Phone: 519-749-4300 ext. 6880 Here 24/7: Mental Health and Crisis Service Team. Phone: 1-844-437-3247 OK2BME: set of support services for lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender or questioning teens in Waterloo. Phone: 519-884-0000 extension 213

1.3.17 Territorial Acknowledgement

Academic freedom at the University of Waterloo We acknowledge that we are living and working on the traditional territory of the Attawandaron (also known as Neutral), Anishinaabe and Haudenosaunee peoples. The University of Waterloo is situated on the Haldimand Tract, the land promised to the Six Nations that includes ten kilometres on each side of the Grand River.

For more information about the purpose of territorial acknowledgements, please see the CAUT Guide to Acknowledging Traditional Territory. Academic freedom at the University of Waterloo

1.3.18 Policy 33, Ethical Behaviour

Policy 33, Ethical Behaviour states, as one of its general principles (Section 1), “The University supports academic freedom for all members of the University community. Academic freedom carries with it the duty to use that freedom in a manner consistent with the scholarly obligation to base teaching and research on an honest and ethical quest for knowledge. In the context of this policy, ‘academic freedom’ refers to academic activities, including teaching and scholarship, as is articulated in the principles set out in the Memorandum of Agreement between the FAUW and the University of Waterloo, 1998 (Article 6). The academic environment which fosters free debate may from time to time include the presentation or discussion of unpopular opinions or controversial material. Such material shall be dealt with as openly, respectfully and sensitively as possible.” This definition is repeated in Policies 70 and 71, and in the Memorandum of Agreement, Section 6

1.4 A look ahead – what we will code

1. Turing Machine
2. Integrate and Fire Neuron

3. Hodgkin-Huxley Neuron
4. Perceptron
5. Hopfield Net
6. Agent Based Model
7. And possibly more

1.5 A look ahead – what we talk about

1. What is cognition?
2. What is a cognitive model?
3. What is the relationship between cognition and neuroscience?
4. All of which will benefit from better understanding what is a theory.

1.6 What is Cognition?

Groups of three. No two members should be the same as the last group. What is Cognition? Each group gets an opinion (want three of four groups) Brainard/Byrne/Heyes/Suddendorf 20 minutes to read and discuss to make sure they understand. Then rotate the groups so that each group has only one member/opinion. 15 minutes to explain the opinions to each other. General discussion.

1.7 Is a mathematical formula a model?

1.7.1 Forgetting Curve — Ebbinghaus

1.7.2 A Mathematical Function

```
import Graphics.Gnuplot.Simple
plotFunc [PNG "./images/expdecay.png"]
(linearScale 100 (1,6))
((\x -> exp (1.0/x)) :: Double -> Double)
```

1.7.3 What can we infer

from the similarity between Figure 1 and Figure 2 ?

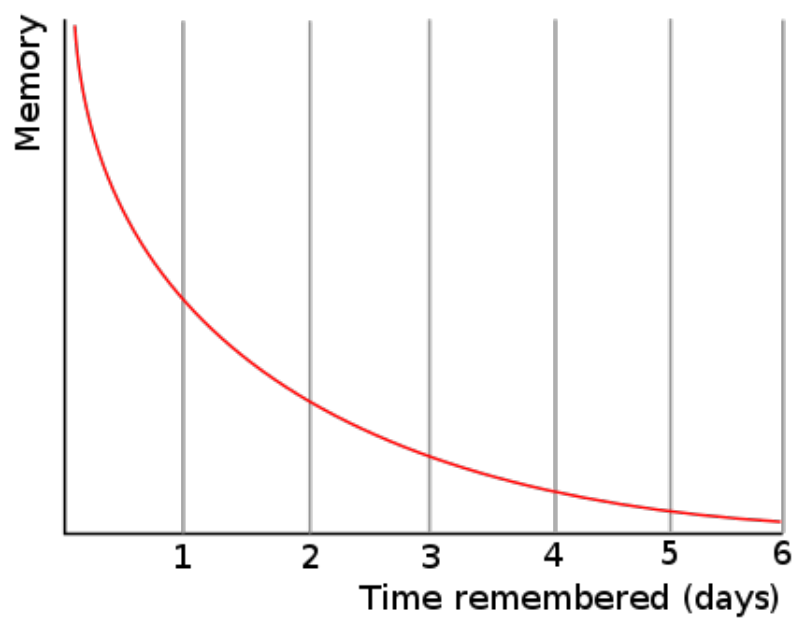


Figure 1: By The original uploader was Icez at English Wikipedia.

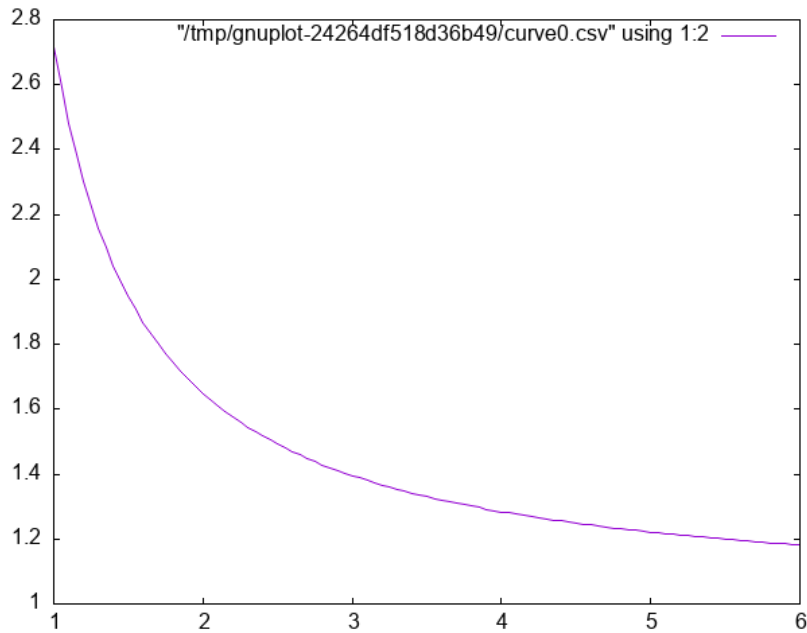


Figure 2: Plot of $e^{\frac{1}{x}}$.

1.7.4 Generate your own plot of the exponential function.

2 Warming Up: Action Potentials

Our goals:

1. Understand what we are trying to model: the action potential.
2. Learn some of the prior work.
3. Understand the mathematical background for an action potential.
 - (a) Simple electronics.
 - (b) Simple differential equations.
4. Make ourselves familiar with the basic notation of these two background areas.
5. Implement simple computational versions of spiking neurons. If you cannot code it, you do not understand it.

2.1 What is an action potential?

1. Draw one.
2. Explain what ions account for the different parts of the curve.
3. Why is an action potential like a flush toilet?
4. Why did/do people use the action potential to argue that brains are like digital computers?
5. Who were McCulloch and Pitts and why are they relevant?
6. Who developed the first detailed biophysical model of the action potential and what became of them?
7. Why would we want to write a program to simulate a spiking neuron?
8. Why might we want a simpler version?
9. What maths are important for modeling spiking neurons?

2.2 Notation

The mathematician's interest in being concise often means that simple ideas get translated to unfamiliar symbols. \ Just because the notation is unfamiliar does not mean the idea is complicated. What does $\sum_{x \in \{1,2,3\}} x = 6$ mean?

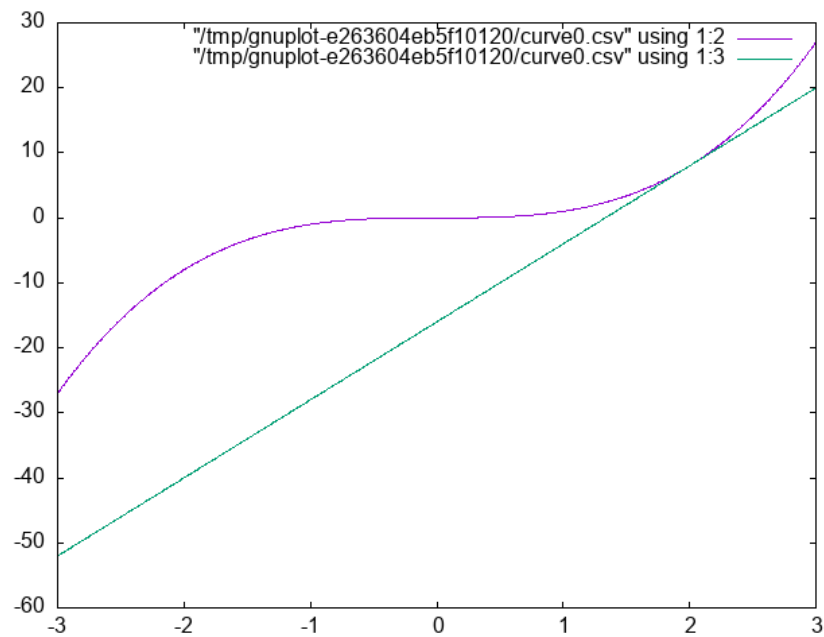
Different mathematical and computational traditions have their own preferences, thus the same idea can have different notations. To a mathematician the $\sqrt{-1} = i$. To the engineer it is j . $\frac{dx}{dt}$ $\dot{x}$ x' $f'(x)$ are all different ways of talking about derivatives.

2.3 Differential Equations

1. What is a differential equation (aka de)?
2. What is a derivative?
3. What is the **definition** of a derivative? $\frac{dx}{dy} = \frac{f(x+\Delta x)-f(x)}{x+\Delta x-x}$
4. What is a slope of a line?
5. Of a curve?

6. Provide examples of phenomena in psychology or neuroscience (other than the action potential) that might be good candidates for this mathematical technique.

```
plotFuncs [PNG "./images/derivExample.png"] (linearScale 1000 (-
3 , 3 ) )
[(\x -> x ** 3) :: Double -> Double
, (\x -> 12 * x - 16) :: Double -> Double ]
```



2.3.1 Using a DE

In computational neuroscience (or psychology) we don't typically "solve" DEs. We use them. We use them to help us move forward in time to understand a process by virtue of what we know about its rate of change. We will see that in a couple of short examples, and then some simple scenarios for you to play with.

2.3.2 Using DEs to compute a square root

```
1 xcubed :: Double -> Double
2 xcubed = (** 3)
3
```

```

4  diffXCubed :: Double -> Double
5  diffXCubed = ( 3 *) . ( ** 2)
6
7  getStep :: Double -> Double -> Double
8  getStep guess goal = ( goal - xcubed guess) / diffXCubed guess
9
10 getCubeRoot :: Double -> Double -> Double -> Double
11 getCubeRoot g i t =
12     let  cg = i + getStep i g
13         myerr = abs (xcubed cg - g) in
14         if myerr > t then getCubeRoot g cg t else cg

```

Now let's test it:

```

:load "./code/sqrt.hs"
getCubeRoot 27 1 0.001
getCubeRoot 8 1 0.001
getCubeRoot 125 1 0.001

```

```

[1 of 2] Compiling Main                ( code/sqrt.hs, interpreted )
Ok, one module loaded.
3.00000005410641766
2.0000004911675504
5.000000000287929

```

2.3.3 Practice Simulating With DEs

1. Frictionless Springs

We want to code neurons, but to get there we should feel comfortable with the underlying tool or we won't be able to adapt it or re-use it for some new purpose. We will start with a very simple and concrete example: the frictionless spring.

$$\frac{d^2s}{dt^2} = -P s$$

where 's' refers to space, 't' refers to time, and 'P' is a constant, often called the spring constant, that indicates how stiff or springy the spring is.

Imagine that you knew this derivative. It would tell you how much space the spring head would move for a given, very small, increment of time. We could then just add this to our current position to get the

new position and repeat. This method of using a derivative to iterate forward is sometimes called the Euler method.

Returning to our definition of the derivative:

$$\frac{s(t+\Delta t)-s(t)}{\Delta t} = \text{velocity} \approx \frac{ds}{dt}$$

But our spring equation is not given in terms of the velocity it is given in terms of the acceleration which is the second derivative. Therefore, to find our new position we need the velocity, but we only have the acceleration. However, if we knew the acceleration and the velocity we could use that to calculate the new velocity. Unfortunately we don't know the velocity, unless ... , maybe we could just assume something. Let's say it is zero because we have started our process where we have stretched the spring, and are holding it, just before letting it go. We have asserted an *initial value*.

How will our velocity change with time?

$$\frac{v(t+\Delta t)-v(t)}{\Delta t} = \text{acceleration} \approx \frac{dv}{dt} = \frac{d^2s}{dt^2}$$

And we have a formula for this. We can now bootstrap our simulation.

Note the similarity of the two functions. You could write a helper function that was generic to this pattern of *old value + rate of change times the time step*, and just used the pertinent values.

How do we know the formula for acceleration? We were given it!

```
import localcode.spring as s
s.plot_spring()
```

(a) Now You Try **Damped Oscillators**

Provide the code and a plot for the damped oscillator. It has the formula of

$$\frac{d^2s}{dt^2} = -P s(t) - k v(t)$$

3 What is computation and what is its role in cognitive science?

Chapter 1 of Physical Computation in Cognitive Science by Nir Fresco

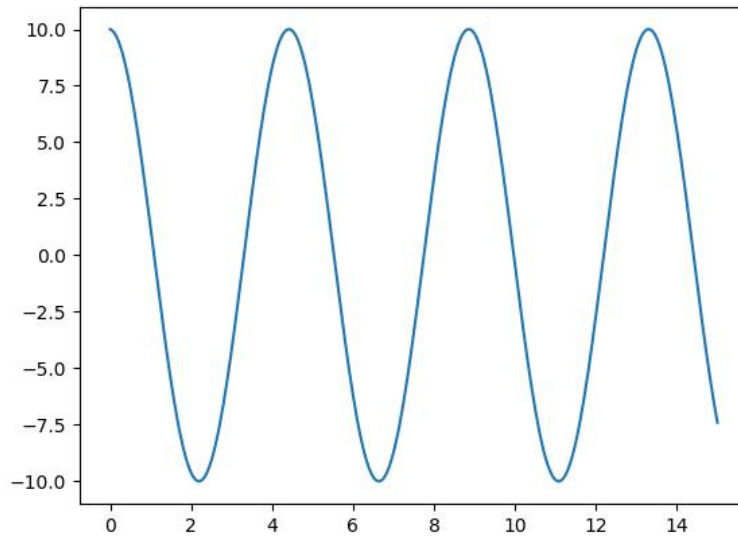


Figure 3: Spring constant of 2 with a starting position of 10.

3.1 What do you think?

1. Computational modeling of cognition and neural systems is/is-not the same as programming.
2. What else could computational modeling be?
3. What are we losing when we treat our computational model as a programmatic black box?
4. Is the computation that is cognitive the same as the computation that takes place in digital computers?
5. If so, why is there more than one programming language?
6. Might our choice of programming language based on features actually influence what we can conceive for a computational model?
7. What does it mean for something to be a model?
8. Is simulation good enough?

9. Is prediction good enough?
10. Do we want a model to *explain* something? And then of course what constitutes explanation?

3.2 What do we need to know?

1. We need to know the facts of the matter, neurally and cognitively.
2. We need to have a clear question.
3. We need to have a theoretical commitment that leads to clear predictions, and guides our evaluation of what to do.
4. Which of course means we need to know what a theory is and how to build one.
5. We need to know the facts of the matter mathematically and programmatically
 - (a) We need to be able to read the maths.
 - (b) We need to be conversant in symbols and notations.
 - (c) We need to know how to express in symbols what we can say in words.
 - (d) We need to know how to express in code what we can write in symbols.

We need to be concerned with all the levels: mind and brain, theory, math, and code. We can abbreviate these as MTMC: mind $\rightarrow$ theory $\rightarrow$ math $\rightarrow$ code; the arrows indicating an ordering on our development.

4

5 Theory

These are just place holders for now.

I have been wondering about the concept of explanation. I don't know if there is an agreed upon definition in this context. How do we know that an observation is "explained" other than that it is predicted by a theory? Or is the mathematics the same, and is explanation synonymous with post-diction? – Joachim Vanderkerckhove

Is the ability to predict the tides a theory of the tides? Is it an explanation of the tides?

Formalizing Verbal Theories. A tutorial by dialogue.

Forms of explanation and understanding for neuroscience and artificial intelligence

Models are Stupid, and We Need More of Them

Productive Explanation: A framework for evaluating explanations in psychological science

Theory Construction Methodology: A practical framework for building theories in psychology

6 Math and Code

We will group these two by subdomains to keep the connections fresh.